Journal of Advertising

ISSN: 0091-3367 (Print) 1557-7805 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/ujoa20

Social Media Influencers and Followers: Theorization of a Trans-Parasocial Relation and Explication of Its Implications for Influencer Advertising

Chen Lou

To cite this article: Chen Lou (2022) Social Media Influencers and Followers: Theorization of a Trans-Parasocial Relation and Explication of Its Implications for Influencer Advertising, Journal of Advertising, 51:1, 4-21, DOI: 10.1080/00913367.2021.1880345

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2021.1880345

View supplementary material

Published online: 05 Mar 2021.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 25851

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Citing articles: 246 View citing articles

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=ujoa20

JOURNAL OF ADVERTISING
2022, VOL. 51, NO. 1, 4–21
https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2021.1880345

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

Social Media Influencers and Followers: Theorization of a Trans-Parasocial Relation and Explication of Its Implications for Influencer Advertising

Chen Lou

Nanyang Technological University, Singapore, Singapore

ABSTRACT

Afforded by new digital technologies, consumer interactions are breaking the boundaries of basic assumptions about interpersonal communication, mass communication, and the concepts arising from the two. By looking into social media influencer–follower relations, this study suggests that the long-held conventional concept of parasocial relation no longer fully encompasses the evolving contemporary human interactions and related relations. The current analysis recommends an updated notion and theorization—a *trans-parasocial relation*—to capture a *collectively reciprocal*, *(a)synchronously interactive*, and *co-created* relation between influencers and their captive followers. This trans-parasocial relation concept offers a foundation on which new communicative and advertising theories can be developed to explicate new forms of social interactions and consumer behavior. More importantly, in view of this trans-parasocial relation, assumptions of the existing persuasion theory—that is, the persuasion knowledge model—need to be reassessed. The current findings demonstrate that persuasion knowledge does not always negatively affect advertising outcomes. Instead, followers indicate mostly benign attitudes toward influencer-sponsored posts, interpret influencers' sponsorship disclosures as genuine and transparent, and internalize disclosure actions as inspiring and admirable. This study further identifies and elucidates several psychological mechanisms that account for followers' overall appreciation of influencer-sponsored posts: *positive bias*, *verification by cross-validation,* and *inspirational internalization*.

Checking out the latest updates of Instagrammers and watching new videos of YouTubers have become a staple leisure activity for many (Leskin 2020). For instance, YouTube boasts 50 million content creators and two billion monthly active users on its platform, and YouTube users watch one billion hours of videos on a daily basis (Omnicore 2020). In particular, the most often watched YouTube content by millennials and generation Z is how-to videos or tutorials, followed by vlogs and unboxing videos (Influencer Marketing Hub 2020). More importantly, users of these social networking sites not only engage with content that is generated by online personalities but also make purchase decisions based on the recommendations of these online personae (Mohsin 2020). Popular online personalities, often being content generators—including Instagrammers, YouTubers, and—who attract a large number of followers and have a significant impact on followers' purchase behavior, are recognized as social media influencers (De Veirman, Cauberghe, and Hudders 2017; Lou and Yuan 2019). Prior research has delineated a fine line between influencers and celebrities by arguing that influencers are those who constantly create useful content to attract a following via interactive social media platforms (Lou and Kim 2019), whereas celebrities who are famous for theatrical talents, such as acting, singing, or sports, often have gained their fame through traditional media, such as movies, TV, and radio (Escalas and Bettman 2017). Furthermore, some argue that influencers are regarded as more credible than celebrities in terms of influencing followers' purchasing behavior, because the former define themselves as ordinary people with a passion for life and their product reviews are considered more authentic and relatable by their followers (Djafarova and Rushworth 2017; Weinswig 2016).

CONTACT Chen Lou chenlou@ntu.edu.sg 31 Nanyang Link, 03-13, Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information, Nanyang Technological University, 637718 Singapore.

Chen Lou (PhD, Michigan State University) is Assistant Professor of Integrated Marketing Communication, Wee Kim Wee School of Communication and Information, Nanyang Technological University.

Supplemental data for this article is available online at https://doi.org/10.1080/00913367.2021.1880345.

Copyright © 2021, American Academy of Advertising

Among the mechanisms that explain the appeal of influencers among followers, the parasocial relation between influencers and their followers has been found to account for the heightened materialistic views and purchase intentions among adolescents, as well as the increased product interests among adult followers (Lou and Kim 2019; Yuan and Lou 2020). Parasocial relation herein refers to the perceived "connectedness that audiences have with media personae beyond momentary exposure" (Bond 2018, p. 459), which is "a more enduring relation that a media user forms with a mediated performer (Dibble, Hartmann, and Rosaen 2016, p. 21). Parasocial relation differs from a closely related term, parasocial interaction, as the latter describes audiences' momentary engagement with media personae through episodic media exposure (Horton and Wohl 1956). Parasocial relation is often considered as one-sided or non-reciprocal between the two involved parties, with one (the audience) knowing more about and being more involved with the other (TV and radio personalities) (Horton and Wohl 1956). However, recent research has also challenged this notion by describing the bidirectional and intimate relation between influencers and followers as "perceived interconnectedness," which is differentiated from the unidirectional parasocial relation concept that was coined in the era of TV and radio (Abidin 2015). Influencer–follower relations are indeed more interactive and reciprocal than what parasocial relation entails (Lou and Kim 2019). Nonetheless, the latest theorization of this influencer–-follower relation is grounded and materialized from the perspective of influencers (e.g., Abidin 2015). Therefore, a lucid theoretical explication of this new relational form between influencers and followers that is based in empirical investigation, from the perspective of followers, is greatly needed.

More importantly, given that influencers are, more or less, driven by "underlying commercial interests," namely, sponsorships or endorsement deals (Abidin and Thompson 2012, p. 472), how this new form of relation configures or explicates consumers' reactions to influencers' sponsored activities is still inconclusive. Prior literature has ascertained that the inclusion of sponsorship disclosures in influencer-sponsored posts helps consumers recognize them as advertising—the activation of cognitive persuasion knowledge—and, thus, cope with persuasive intents through developing skepticism or negative attitudes toward the sponsored posts or influencers (e.g., De Jans and Hudders 2020; Evans et al. 2017). However, some recent studies revealed that influencers' sponsorship disclosures, which signal "honesty, openness and transparency of the influencers," actually bolstered followers' trust in and satisfaction with influencers (Dhanesh and Duthler 2019, p. 10). Furthermore, Lou and colleagues (Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019) analyzed a large collection of influencer-sponsored posts on Instagram and found that the inclusion of disclosures (i.e., no disclosure versus clear or ambiguous disclosure) did not affect followers' liking of the posts, commenting on the posts, or negative sentiment manifested in the comments. The inconsistency regarding how followers react to influencer-sponsored posts (with or without disclosure) reveals an evident research gap, thus calling for new inquiries and explications in this area.

Collectively, there are notable gaps in the extant literature on influencer advertising and influencer–follower relation that warrants more in-depth and nuanced explication. First, there is a lack of a thorough and systematic theorization of this new relational form between influencers and followers from the followers' perspective (e.g., Abidin 2015). Second, recent research shows that this influencer–follower relation can mitigate the negative effect of advertising literacy—activated by sponsorship disclosure—on advertising effectiveness (e.g., Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020). Furthermore, as mentioned above, followers' overall tolerance toward influencer-sponsored posts has challenged the assumptions of the persuasion knowledge model (PKM) (e.g., Dhanesh and Duthler 2019; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019). It is thus imperative to untangle the underlying psychological processes that expound followers' reactions to influencer-sponsored posts. Therefore, this study seeks to revisit and redefine the parasocial relation in the influencer context and explicates how it informs followers' reactions to influencer-sponsored content. As one of the most technologically developed nations and with a 75% social media penetration rate (Müller 2020), Singapore offers an ideal venue to answer these research inquiries. Influencers in Singapore are playing an increasing role in followers' purchase behavior, with the 18- to 34-year-old group being influenced the most (Müller 2019). Since Singapore is a developed city-state that has been greatly influenced by the Western modernization and related concepts (Chang 2003), research on influencer practices in Singapore context are never unique to the local context and has been widely applied to varied cultural sites (e.g., Abidin 2015, 2016) work on influencers in Singapore). Through a series of in-depth interviews involving social media users who are following influencers in Singapore and guided by the concept of parasocial

relation and PKM, this study proposes that a new conceptualization of *trans-parasocial relation*, marked by influencers who engage followers through *collectively reciprocal*, *(a)synchronously interactive*, and *co-created* interactions and relation development. Moreover, this study shows that followers respond to influencer-sponsored posts with overall benign and appreciative attitudes through the following psychological mechanisms: *positive bias*, *verification by cross-validation*, and *inspirational internalization*. This research yields significant theoretical contributions by offering theorization of this new and evolving influencer–follower relation and delineating the implications of this relation for future research on influencer advertising. Furthermore, the current findings offer actionable recommendations for influencers in terms of building organic and cordial relations with their followers and also crafting a validated checklist that guides brands in conducting efficient influencer campaigns.

Literature Review

Social Media Influencer and Influencer Marketing

The use of celebrities in marketing communications has persisted over the past few decades (Kaikati 1987). Brands and firms invest in employing celebrities to promote products or brands—namely celebrity endorsement—in the hope of transferring the desirable qualities of celebrities (e.g., attractiveness, likeability, trustworthiness) to generate favorable campaign outcomes (Erdogan 1999). In recent years, a new type of "online celebrity," who is popular and influential among online and social media platforms, has been gaining increasing traction with brand endorsement and sponsorship (Djafarova and Rushworth 2017). These "online celebrities," termed as social media influencers, are often popular social media personalities who constantly create and disseminate useful and organic content within a knowledge domain, project authentic personae, curate intimate relations with a large following, and thus wield influence over followers' purchases and decision making (Campbell and Farrell 2020; Lou and Yuan 2019). Adopting the categorization of influencers proposed by Campbell and Farrell (2020)—including celebrity influencer and mega-, macro-, micro- and nano-influencer, this study focuses on the self-made "bottom-up, grass-roots" influencers "who have gained fame as content generators" (Lou and Yuan 2019, p. 60), excluding the "celebrity influencers"—those who "experienced fame and notoriety prior to or independent from the evolution of social media" (Campbell and Farrell 2020, p. 3). Expenditure on influencer marketing has been skyrocketing and is expected to reach $15 billion by 2022 (Schomer 2019). More importantly, a survey conducted by Google showed that 7 in 10 teens mentioned that they feel closer to YouTubers more than traditional celebrities and 4 out of 10 millennials believe that their favorite YouTuber "understands them better than their friends" (O'Neil-Hart and Blumenstein 2016). Influencer endorsement, or influencer marketing, may serve just as well as, or even better than, celebrity endorsement in driving desirable campaign results.

Recent research on influencer marketing has documented the appeal of influencers among certain age groups (e.g., adolescents) (Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; De Veirman, Hudders and Nelson 2019). Also explored are the roles of source credibility, content value, parasocial interaction/relationship, and congruity in the effectiveness of influencer campaigns (Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; De Veirman, Cauberghe, and Hudders 2017; Lou and Yuan 2019; Schouten, Janssen, and Verspaget 2020). Studies have further examined the agency perspective on influencer campaigns (Childers, Lemon, and Hoy 2019), as well as the effect of sponsorship disclosure on consumer reactions (e.g., De Veirman and Hudders 2020; Evans, Hoy, and Childers 2018; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019; Van Reijmersdal et al. 2020). Among these studies, those who have examined the relation between influencers and followers often applied the parasocial interaction or parasocial relation paradigm to theorize and explicate the relation between influencers and their followers and its effect on downstream consumer behaviors (e.g., Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; Hwang and Zhang 2018; Yuan and Lou 2020). Yet, the relation between influencers and followers may deviate from that of TV/radio personae and audiences—on which the term parasocial relation/interaction has been premised (Horton and Wohl 1956).

In particular, many influencers actively reply to followers' coveted comments and arrange offline meet-ups or live-streaming sessions to facilitate more interactive communications (Abidin 2015). Influencers also purposely disclose intimate personal stories or life episodes to project commonality and manifest authenticity (Pöyry et al. 2019). More importantly, influencers communicate "reciprocal intimacies" with their followers to signal appreciation and acknowledge followers' support, including liking or retweeting followers' mentions or comments and featuring followers' posts or stories (Abidin 2015). Many

influencers regularly reciprocate with followers with free endorsed products and other types of support. Furthermore, influencers often actively solicit feedback or take account of requests from their followers for content creation and interaction topics (Abidin 2015). Collectively, the relation between influencers and followers, from the influencers' perspective, have been found to be more interactive, bidirectional, co-constructed, and intimate than what the notion of parasocial relation has originally encompassed (Abidin 2015). Against this backdrop, this study revisits the parasocial relation below to theorize and materialize the relation between influencers and followers, from the followers' perspective.

Parasocial Relation

The concept of parasocial relation, originally introduced by Horton and Wohl (1956), describes an illusory and enduring social relation with media personae—including celebrities and media figures or characters—through mediated encounters, which is often experienced by the audience. At times, parasocial relation and parasocial interaction have been used interchangeably (e.g., Tsai and Men 2013). Yet, they are essentially different, as parasocial interaction describes the short-term and episode-based engagement with media personae whereas parasocial relation captures the lasting bonds that the audiences have developed with media personae (Bond 2018). Parasocial relation is understood as one-sided or nonreciprocal because the audiences often know the media personae well, whereas the latter barely knows the former (Escalas and Bettman 2017; Tsai and Men 2013). Horton and Wohl (1956) coined this term in the era of TV and radio; however, neither TV nor radio enables audiences to directly interact with media personae (e.g., celebrities, characters). Social media, otherwise, facilitate users to engage in interactions with their favorite media personalities (e.g., liking, commenting on, or sharing their posts) and also enable these media personalities to disclose their life episodes to followers or personally reply to followers' comments, which contributes to greater intimacy and enhanced reciprocity as perceived by the followers (e.g., Colliander and Dahlén 2011; Tsai and Men 2013; Yuan and Lou 2020). When it comes to the interaction between influencers and followers, influencers not only regularly interact with followers and generate useful content appealing to followers but also engage followers in the co-creation of their content or strategies (e.g., creating videos upon the requests of followers) (Abidin 2015). Through cumulative interactions and/or the process of content co-creation, followers can often develop enduring attachment to influencers (e.g., Abidin 2015; Bond 2016; Chen 2016; Sokolova and Kefi 2020; Yuan and Lou 2020).

More importantly, the relation between influencers and followers has been argued to be different from parasocial relation in multiple ways (Abidin 2015). Based on observations of and interviews with influencers in Singapore, Abidin (2015) argued that, first, the parasocial relation is premised on theatrics displayed by media personae, whereas the crux of the relation between influencers and followers is intimacy. Second, the relation between influencers and followers is mediated by a more flat and interactive social media infrastructure, whereas parasocial relation is often facilitated by top-down, one-to-many mass media channels. Third, regarding the parasocial relation context, mediated content disseminated to audiences is often constructed by "producers," whereas content propagated by influencers are often co-created by both influencers and followers. More importantly, the communication between influencers and followers are unprecedentedly more interactive than before, and offline meetup opportunities with influencers further makes followers believe that they have an interpersonal, relatable, and intimate "friendship" with influencers (Abidin 2015; O'Neil-Hart and Blumenstein 2016). However, these conclusions are drawn from the perspective of influencers. What does the influencer–-follower relation entail and implicate, from the perspective of followers? What are the characteristics of this relation, and are they distinct from the notion of parasocial relation? To answer these questions, we formulate the following questions:

> **RQ1:** From the perspective of followers, what are the characteristics of the relation between influencers and followers?
>
> **RQ2:** How does the relation between influencers and followers differ from the existing notion of parasocial relation between media personae and audiences?

Recent research that adopts the paradigm of parasocial relation to capture the influencer–follower relation revealed that parasocial relation moderates the effect of sponsorship disclosure on brand attitudes (Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020) and the effect of persuasion knowledge on purchase intentions and electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) (Hwang and Zhang 2018). It is also found to mediate the effect of influencer source credibility, influencer content factors, or communication fairness between influencers and followers on followers' materialistic views,

purchase intentions, or product interests in influencer-sponsored posts (Lou and Kim 2019; Yuan and Lou 2020). In short, regardless of what the relation between influencers and followers encompasses, this relation is expected to affect followers' reactions to influencer-sponsored posts. We draw on the PKM to further explicate this process.

PKM and Followers' Reactions to Influencer-Sponsored Posts

According to recent studies on influencer marketing, followers are likely to activate their persuasion knowledge (PK) when being exposed to influencer-sponsored posts/videos that include clear disclosures (e.g., De Jans and Hudders 2020; Evans et al. 2017). As a construct that originated from the PKM (Friestad and Wright 1994), PK explicates how consumers understand the reasons that advertisers try to influence them within a certain context and thus develop knowledge to tackle marketers' persuasive intents and tactics and adjust their product/brand attitudes and purchase intentions accordingly. PK is two-dimensional, covering both conceptual persuasion knowledge (CPK) and attitudinal persuasion knowledge (APK) (Boerman, Van Reijmersdal, and Neijens 2012). While CPK refers to one's ability to recognize a message's persuasive intent, tactic, and appeal (Boerman, Van Reijmersdal, and Neijens 2012), APK denotes an affective dimension describing how one develops a critical attitude, such as a distrustful belief or dislike, to tackle persuasive intents (Boerman, Willemsen, and Van Der Aa 2017).

Prior research demonstrated that recognizing a persuasive message as an advertisement (CPK) precedes consumers' subsequent coping behavior of developing critical or distrusting beliefs (APK) toward the message (Rozendaal et al. 2011). Informed by the PKM, a multitude of studies have indicated that inclusion of a clear sponsorship disclosure in sponsored ads activates followers' CPK and their consequent APK (e.g., Boerman, Willemsen, and Van Der Aa 2017; Evans et al. 2017; Jung and Heo 2019; Wojdynski and Evans 2016). Relevant to the influencer context, one line of recent research focuses on how advertising recognition, triggered by sponsorship disclosures, negatively affects campaign outcomes—including brand attitudes, attitudes toward the influencer, or purchase intentions—through the generation of ad skepticism (i.e., APK) (e.g., De Jans, Cauberghe, and Hudders 2018; De Veirman and Hudders 2020; Van Reijmersdal and van Dam 2020; Van Reijmersdal et al. 2020). For instance, Van Reijmersdal and colleagues (Van Reijmersdal et al. 2020) found that disclosure displayed prior to the start of an influencer-sponsored video (versus a disclosure shown concurrently when the video starts playing) led to higher ad recognition which, in turn, resulted in more critical attitudes toward the sponsored content and subsequently less favorable attitudes toward the brand and the influencer.

However, another line of research reveals that the activation of PK does not necessarily lead to negative persuasion outcomes (e.g., De Jans and Hudders 2020; Dhanesh and Duthler 2019; Kay, Mulcahy, and Parkinson 2020; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019; Van Dam and van Reijmersdal 2019). For instance, De Jans and Hudders (2020) found that the inclusion of influencer-generated disclosure (versus no disclosure) in sponsored videos did not decrease followers' admiration toward the influencer or parasocial interaction intentions with the influencer. Kay and colleagues (2020) demonstrated that sponsored posts with clear disclosures that were posted by micro-influencers actually led to higher purchase intentions than the same posts without disclosures. Dhanesh and Duthler (2019) argued that influencers' sponsorship disclosures could imply honesty and transparency of the influencers, which can further enhance followers' trust in them. These findings and notions, however, contradict the basic assumptions regarding the negative effect of PK on consumer reactions to persuasive messages, wherein followers are expected to indicate heightened critical attitudes and increased skepticisms toward influencer posts or influencers after recognizing their sponsored posts—indicated by disclosures—as advertising. Collectively, we argue that the inconsistency in the extant findings regarding followers' reactions to influencer-sponsored posts can be partially explained by the dynamic and intimate relation between influencers and their followers (e.g., Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; Hwang and Zhang 2018) along with other potential moderators (e.g., influencer–brand congruity, disclosure memory). This study focuses on the role of influencer–follower relation and explores the potential processes through which this intimate influencer–follower relation shapes follower reactions to influencer-sponsored posts below.

Influencer–Follower Relation and Followers' Reactions to Influencer-Sponsored Posts

Past literature has largely agreed that parasocial relations can enhance persuasion (e.g., Colliander and

Dahlén 2011; Escalas and Bettman 2017; Russell, Stern, and Stern 2006). For instance, Escalas and Bettman (2017) revealed that the parasocial relation that consumers formed toward celebrity endorsers mediated the effect of celebrity endorsement on self–brand connections. Russell and colleagues (2006) proposed balance theory and argued that consumers' parasocial attachment to sitcom characters drove them to align their attitudes toward product placements with that of the media personae's attitudes toward those products. Similarly, Colliander and Dahlén (2011) proposed that parasocial relation formed between readers and blogs (versus online magazines) accounted for its greater persuasiveness. In addition, users' parasocial relation with brands' Facebook representatives has been found to boost their engagement with brand pages on Facebook (Tsai and Men 2013). Relative to the influencer context, parasocial relation has been found to decrease the negative effect of persuasion knowledge on brand attitudes (Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020) as well as purchase intentions and eWOM intentions (Hwang and Zhang 2018).

In this research, we argue that due to the intimate, bidirectional, co-created, and interactive relation established between influencers and their followers, the inclusion of disclosure (especially an explicit one) may activate followers' CPK (i.e., they can recognize the persuasive nature of the sponsored posts), but it may neither engender critical and distrusting attitudes predicted by PKM—namely, the generation of APK—nor negatively influence followers' downstream consumption intentions (e.g., Dhanesh and Duthler 2019; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019). However, how followers reconcile the persuasive nature of influencer-sponsored posts with their attachment to influencers is unknown; the processes or psychological mechanisms through which followers balance their reactions to influencer sponsorships and their experienced intimate relations with influencers are yet to be examined. Therefore, this study proposes the following question:

> **RQ3:** How, and through which mechanisms, do followers react to influencer-sponsored posts in view of their attachment to influencers?

Method

Participants and Procedure

To answer the research questions, we conducted a series of in-depth one-on-one interviews with 26 participants in Singapore. Recruitment ceased when no new points or ideas seemed to occur in the conversations (Corbin and Strauss 2008). The enrolled participants have to be active social media users who have at least one favorite influencer whom they have been following and checking their updates at least once a week. They were recruited through both online and offline advertisements disseminated in a large university campus and received S$10 each for their participation that ranged from around half an hour to one hour. We had 16 female and 10 male participants, who aged from 22 to 32 years old (M_{age} = 24.85, SD = 2.91). Among the participants, seven were employed, while the rest were undergraduate or graduate students (see Table 1 for demographics). Most of them were Chinese (69%), with 8% Malay, and 23% Indians. The ethnicity distribution of the participants broadly parallels the ethnic composition in Singapore (Government of Singapore 2019). All interviews were conducted in English, except for one interviewee who spoke mainly Chinese, with a mixture of both English and Chinese words. Her responses were all translated into English and the interviewer is bilingual in English and Chinese.

Table 1. Demographics of the participants.

Pseudonym	Age	Gender	Ethnicity	Occupation
Jean	23	Female	Chinese	Student
Belle	22	Female	Chinese	Student
Elly	22	Female	Chinese	Student
Nami	22	Female	Chinese	Student
Alle	25	Female	Chinese	UI/UX designer
Ken	24	Male	Chinese	Audit associate
Sean	25	Male	Chinese	Student
Roy	22	Male	Indian	Student
Nina	22	Female	Malay	Student
Lia	22	Female	Chinese	Student
Renie	22	Female	Malay	Student
Jess	25*	Female	Chinese	Student
Jun	25*	Male	Chinese	Student
Matt	28	Male	Chinese	Student
Joel	24	Male	Indian	Student
Yee	24	Male	Chinese	Student
Leon	25	Male	Chinese	Student
Dina	24	Female	Chinese	Student
Juri	27	Female	Chinese	Student
Wen	27	Female	Chinese	Senior executive
Zoee	32	Female	Chinese	Program coordinator
Foo	26	Male	Chinese	Student
Pavati	25*	Female	Indian	Student
Adah	22	Female	Indian	Marketing analyst
Krisha	29	Female	Indian	Engineer
Hasim	32	Male	Indian	Research associate

Note. *Participants who declined to be identified with exact age (replaced with mean).

Each interview was conducted in a location at the participant's convenience, mostly in public places. The interviews were audio-recorded. Participants were first asked to read and sign a consent form informing them that the whole interview would be audio-recorded. A trained interviewer conducted all the interviews by following a semi-structured protocol

that covers the research questions and also asked follow-up questions when necessary (see online supplement Appendix A). The interviewer manually transcribed the recordings verbatim by repeatedly listening to each of the recordings. The interviewer spent an average of two hours in transcribing each recording and made sure that only one recording was transcribed per day.

Data Analysis

Two coders conducted a three-step analysis of transcripts (Tracy 2013). First, the two coders engaged in the open/initial-coding stage when they read the transcripts line-by-line several times and assigned initial codes to the transcripts (e.g., codes like "influencer/celebrity definition," "describing influencer-follower relation"). The transcriptions were analyzed using the constant comparative method of qualitative analysis (Glaser 1965). The two coders independently coded all the transcripts. Second, the two coders discussed the codes that emerged in their independent analysis and noted identical codes and underlying concepts relevant to this research. The two coders then initiated the axial/hierarchical-coding stage, when the coders individually grouped and organized the initial codes to second-level analytic or interpretive concepts (e.g., the prevailing themes/characteristics of influencer–follower relation). The existing literature on parasocial relationship and PKM guided and helped the coders to broadly categorize codes under each concept. These second-level codes often "serve[s] to explain, theorize, and synthesize" transcripts (Tracy 2013, p. 194). Finally, the two coders discussed the second-level codes that emerged in each of their analyses and reached consensus on how they can be merged to answer the research questions. The principal researcher, who has the theoretical knowledge, theorized the findings and contrasted them with existing theories (Tracy 2013).

Furthermore, given that the evaluative criteria of qualitative research differs from that of quantitative research (Haley 1996; Lincoln and Guba 1985), to ensure the rigor and validity of the current analysis, this study adopted the constructivist or interpretive paradigm to benchmark the current data analysis against the primary trustworthiness criteria (i.e., credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability) (Chen and Haley 2014; Lincoln and Guba 1985). In particular, several steps and measures were undertaken to warrant the trustworthiness of the analysis, reflected in dimensions like credibility, transferability, dependability, and confirmability. Credibility herein refers to the adequate and authentic representations of multiple realities, making sure that the reconstructions that arise from the inquiries are credible (Hirschman 1986). To enhance its credibility, the researcher engaged in the following measures. First, the interviewer has been well trained before data collection, discussed the issues emerged in the initial process with expert researchers in this area in a timely manner, and fine-tuned the stance to better understand the participants. Second, a semi-structured protocol allowed the interviewer to flexibly follow the discourse or narrative of the participants and probe for more information when necessary. Third, all interviews were audio-recorded for verbatim transcriptions. Last, the researcher also invited an expert in qualitative research to assess the data analysis process and procedure employed in this study, which served as a further cross-check of its validity.

Next, as qualitative research is not often concerned with the generalizability of a specific finding, transferability herein describes how well one manifestation or interpretation of a phenomenon in a given context transfers to a second setting (Hirschman 1986). Transferability of the analysis can be assessed on a post hoc basis. We explicated and justified how the current findings could be transferable to other cultural sites with existing evidence in the discussion section. Additionally, dependability criterion is approximately analogous to the concept of reliability in quantitative research, which speaks to the consistency and stability during data handling. To enhance the current analysis' dependability, as described, this study engaged two coders in a rigorous three-step procedure and held discussions intermittently to solve inconsistencies. The last criterion—confirmability—is "functionally analogous to the notions of neutrality and objectively" (Hirschman 1986, p. 246), which describes the extent to which interpretations of the researcher are nonprejudiced and supportable from the actual data (Hirschman 1986). To ensure the confirmability of the analysis, this study has provided verbatim quotes (all pseudonymized) or original expressions from the participants to support each thematic finding that emerged in the analysis (Chen and Haley 2014).

Results

The participants described influencers more like regular people who have a sizable following and who can influence or shape others' decisions, behaviors, and/or opinions. The participants also emphasized that

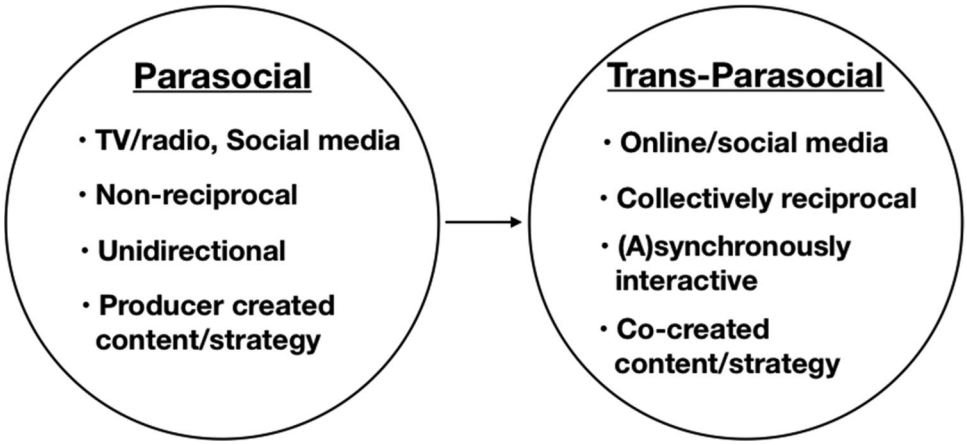

Figure 1. The key characteristics of parasocial relation and trans-parasocial relation.

influencers have the capacity to impart useful knowledge, including both domain knowledge and product (usage) information, and that they attract sponsorships from brands because of their organic sharing. The results showed that followers, indeed, consider their relations with influencers (versus celebrities) as more interpersonal, more intimate, and more like relatable "friendships" (Abidin 2015; O'Neil-Hart and Blumenstein 2016). The participants assign a high level of trust toward their favorite influencers. Regarding their interactions with influencers, most participants describe influencers as highly responsive to followers who invest greatly in relation-building with followers. Most of the participants religiously follow influencers' updates and perceive them as trustworthy and genuine. When being asked to name the platforms through which they follow influencers, most of them mentioned Instagram and YouTube, and some listed Facebook, LinkedIn, Snapchat, Weibo, or WeChat. The participants listed a wide range of influencer types, including those focusing on lifestyle, science, politics, sports, tech, live-streaming, fashion, dancing, and beauty.

Influencer–Follower Relation: Collectively Reciprocal, (A)synchronously Interactive, and Co-created

RQ1 and RQ2 asked about the characteristics of the relation between influencers and followers and how it differs from the notion of parasocial relation between media personae and audiences. Three key characteristics of influencer–follower relation emerged from the analysis and indeed set this relation apart from the mostly non-reciprocal and one-way nature of parasocial relation. The relation between influencers and followers are complex, multifaceted, and dynamic, which can be reciprocal and interactive, depending on the contexts. We termed this new updated format of influencer–follower relation as *trans-parasocial relation*, which exhibits the following characteristics: *collectively reciprocal*, *(a)synchronously interactive*, and *co-created* (see Figure 1). These traits distinguish influencer–follower relation from the concept of parasocial relation between media personae and audiences.

Collectively Reciprocal

Parasocial relation entails one-way, illusory social relation in which the audiences often react to, observe, or know about their favorite media personae well while the media personae know little about the audiences or their actions (Bond 2018; Horton and Wohl 1956). This illusory relation may develop to a profound and intimate degree from the perspective of audiences (Horton and Wohl 1956). Parasocial relation, for the most part, implies reciprocity via imagined intimacy perceived by the audiences, but it lacks real reciprocity. Reciprocity herein refers to "users' willingness to return favors in building mutual interactions" (Li et al. 2018, p. 1643). In this mass media personae–audience relation, audiences have no way to receive equal return favors from the media personae for the level of engagement or obsession that they have forged with the media personae, over accumulative parasocial interactions mediated by traditional media. However, in the current influencer–follower relation, influencers often do return favors by actively and regularly responding to representative comments, inquiries, or requests from the followers. The participants described their relations with influencers as more partially reciprocal, as the influencers make efforts to reach out to their followers quite often, try their best to reply to top comments, feature and cover certain topics upon the requests of the followers, give away

free publicity products, and organize offline meet-ups. Renie, a 22-year-old female participant who has been following a dancer influencer on Instagram, described the relation among the influencer, herself, and other followers:

> "Quite reciprocal, but not very. Like it's not very one-sided also; like she's not actively replying (to) every single one (comment), but when she has the time, she does reply to certain comments."

Similarly, a male participant who has been following a science influencer on YouTube also indicated that the influencer often attends to what his followers need:

> "Some comments are suggesting him to explain more about bitcoin to us, and after a few months he made a video explaining bitcoin and those cryptocurrencies." (Leon, 25, male)

The participants also acknowledged that their relations with the influencers are not completely reciprocal, but they consider that most influencers are very responsive and make great efforts to reciprocate. This reciprocity may not be granted to every individual follower, but more in a collective sense, namely accommodating to collective demands from the followers by replying to a segment of the comments or most often asked questions. Moreover, Elly, a 22-year-old female participant, emphasized the importance of this collective reciprocity when evaluating her attachment to influencers and indicated that:

> "It is important to think that relationships with influencers are reciprocal, as having one-sided relationships with influencers is very superficial. … However, having a reciprocal relationship with influencers is what followers would want, and is also why influencers want to be influencers—they want to inspire people and spread joy to others."

(A)synchronously Interactive

The parasocial relation between media personae and audiences used to be a one-way, one-sided communication broadcast to the audiences, which is often controlled by the performers or the media personae (Abidin 2015; Horton and Wohl 1956). Recent research extended this original notion intrinsic to traditional media like TV/radio to the interactive social media context (e.g., Colliander and Dahlén 2011; Lou and Kim 2019; Tsai and Men 2013). Some argued that interactive online and social media platforms facilitate stronger parasocial interactions between media personae and audiences (e.g., Colliander and Dahlén 2011; Tsai and Men 2013), as audiences can not only observe the actions of media personae (e.g., bloggers) but also respond to their messages. Interactivity refers to the extent to which individuals can communicate directly with each other, regardless of time or distance (Blattberg and Deighton 1991). Interactivity also describes "the extent to which users can participate in modifying the format and content of a mediated environment in real time" (Steuer 1992, p. 84). Judged from these perspectives, interactions between media personae and audiences are not completely interactive. However, with respect to influencer–follower interaction, this study argues that it is interactive to a much greater extent, either synchronously through live-streaming sessions or meet-ups, or asynchronously through online comments, online polls, or live videos (e.g., Instagram). For instance, Zoee, a 32-year-old female, described her asynchronous interaction with one of the YouTubers whom she is following:

> "More on the ground I would think, they will reach out to their audience far more than celebrities. … Like if we comment on their YouTube, he will reply."

Sean, a 25-year-old male, concurred with the perceived largely interactive nature of interactions with influencers and indicated that:

> "I think most of them are responsive, it seems that the wants of their followers are more important to them."

Some participants specified that, for live-streaming influencers, their interactions with followers are synchronously interactive, real-time, and efficient. They joined the influencer-initiated live-streaming sessions a couple times per week and enjoyed interactions with the influencers. For instance, Jess, a 25-year-old female participant, mentioned that:

> "He does live broadcasting and audience can ask him questions; we can always get his replies from the *Taobao* live broadcasting."

Co-created

Horton and Wohl (1956) described parasocial relation as nondialectical, which was largely controlled by the media personae and did not involve mutual development. Either the media personae or the audiences have the right to withdraw if either finds the interactions unsatisfying, and audiences are often receptive to media personae's values and motives without much say in this process (Horton and Wohl 1956). However, the influencer–follower relation accommodates a progressive and mutual growth of shared values and aims involving both influencers and followers, meaning that followers can participate in the co-

creation process of influencers' values, aims, or motives. Almost all participants emphasized that influencers crowdsource advice from their followers on what to offer and also proactively seek followers' suggestions on content creation and topics of interaction. Adah, a 22-year-old female, reflected on her favorite YouTuber as follows:

> "I do feel that influencers take their followers' thoughts into account when creating content. They often read comments and ask for ideas of what content their followers would like them to produce."

Also, the products—"performance" or "personae"—offered by media personae remains standardized and unchanged, which was often regulated and formulated by the industry or his/her managers (Horton and Wohl 1956). Yet, influencers, as content generators, are constantly adjusting their content offering and have autonomy over what to offer to their followers through back-and-forth interactions with followers. Another participant also concurred with the co-creation nature of influencer–follower interaction and relation formation:

> "They will look at comments, especially YouTubers, they will look at comments on their videos and then create videos to entertain these comments. Influencers will take the feedback seriously and then curate their content based on the comments that were given." (Sean, 25, male)

In short, this new format of relation between influencers and followers surpasses and extends the extant assumptions of parasocial relation that center on media personae and audiences and democratizes the interaction between followers and influencers. Taking a step further, how this new relation may affect the persuasive outcomes of influencer advertising warrants more profound and granular inquires. Currently, one line of the extant research focused on how the influencer–follower relation (mostly examined through the lens of parasocial relation) mitigates the negative effect of advertising literacy/persuasion knowledge—activated by sponsorship disclosure—on advertising outcomes (e.g., Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; Hwang and Zhang 2018). Furthermore, recent research has demonstrated that followers will not necessarily lower their admiration or interaction intentions toward the influencers if they find out that the influencers are promoting sponsored products (De Jans and Hudders 2020), and followers react to influencer-sponsored posts similar as they do with regular posts (Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019). Collectively, it is plausible that the enhanced relation between influencers and their followers plays a role in the process through which followers evaluate and respond to influencer-sponsored content. More importantly, recent research has revealed that followers often react to influencer-sponsored content quite positively—even when the sponsorship relations were explicitly disclosed (e.g., Dhanesh and Duthler 2019; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019), which largely challenged the assumptions of persuasion knowledge model. Yet, considering the influence of this intimate, bidirectional, co-created, and mostly interactive relation with their coveted influencers, the strategies or underlying mechanisms through which followers form their overall benign or positive reactions to influencer-sponsored posts are unknown. The second aim of this study is to fill in this gap and shed light on the potential processes.

Strategies to Influencer-Sponsored Posts: Positively Biased, Normalized, and Rationalized

RQ3 asked how and through which mechanisms followers react to influencer-sponsored posts in view of their attachment to the influencers. This study revealed that the participants upheld overall benevolent attitudes toward influencers' commercial activities, including sponsored posts. To account for the generally positive attitudinal evaluation, this study found that the participants employed varied psychological mechanisms or strategies to normalize or accept the fact that influencers are leveraging their influence among their followers for commercial gains: *positive bias*, *verification by cross-validation*, and *inspirational internalization*.

Positive Bias

Per the assumptions of the persuasion knowledge model, if consumers recognize a persuasive message as advertising, they are likely to generate critical attitudes or skepticisms toward the messages and accordingly decrease their attitudes toward the source (Friestad and Wright 1994). Yet, most of the participants in this study expressed positive bias toward their favorite influencers' endorsements or sponsorship activities, regardless of whether those sponsorship activities have been disclosed or not. For instance, Sean, a 25-year-old male participant, argued that,

> "By being sponsored, it doesn't undermine the reliability of the post, like what if the influencer is saying is the truth, then the fact that it is sponsored would not make it less true."

Some participants mentioned that they understood well that influencers need to somehow make a living since they are investing their time in creating free

content. Wen, a 27-year-old female, revealed that she is fine with sponsored posts, as long as there is "a balance of personal and work content (sponsored posts)." The participants also applaud the transparency of disclosing sponsorship deals to followers, as it "shows (his) honesty" to followers (Yee, a 24-year-old male). Some also indicated that they simply trust what the influencers promoted as "they would not want to bring down their (travel) pros' names" in their respective domains (Nina, a 22-year-old female).

Another 22-year-old female, Adah, believed in the benevolent nature of the influencers and held very positive attitude toward influencer-sponsored posts, including the nondisclosed ones:

> "(For nondisclosed sponsored posts), it doesn't affect my attitude personally. I understand that it helps them to continue to produce the content they do and like to believe that they wouldn't actively promote harmful products to their followers."

Verification by Cross-Validation

Although most participants expressed positive bias toward influencer sharing, including sponsored content, they also indicated that they don't always readily take in all sponsored information without their own background checking. Most of the participants mentioned that they have the autonomy to either follow suit or not when exposed to sponsored posts, which also explained why they hold a relatively tolerant stance on sponsored content. Roy, a 22-year-old male explained:

> "(For disclosed sponsorships) I don't really feel much, cause he did disclose it; (for those sponsorships that were not disclosed), not really affected (me) much because it is still my choice whether I buy the product or not, and I will cross reference with other sources before buying."

Wen, a 27-year-old female, held similar viewpoint regarding her approach toward influencer-sponsored posts:

> "I think that sometimes they may forget to include the sponsor, so for me it doesn't really matter if it's sponsored or not sponsored, it's for me to judge whether what they post is good or not."

Most of the participants, to a large extent, consider influencers as credible sources and trust what they share due to their expertise, as a 25-year-old male, Jun, mentioned, "I trust what he said. He seldom has any flaws or mistakes in his videos." Yet, this doesn't preclude followers from seeking verifications or cross-reference from friends, family members, or other influencers before they decide to make an actual purchase. Zoee, a 32-year-old female, summarized:

> "I will take it with a pinch of salt, just for me to gain awareness of certain products, but I will not entirely believe what he shares about the good sides of the product. But rather, I would use this as the first touchpoint to know about this product, then subsequently, through word of mouth, through online reviews, then learn more about these products."

Inspirational Internalization

One of the major drivers of followers' attachment to influencers is influencers' inspirational personae (Ki et al. 2020). Influencers who are inspiring in some respects—being a domain expert or having aesthetic taste or appealing style—are likely to draw followers' liking, following, and affection (Ki et al. 2020), as these influencers help fulfill followers' need for ideality or self-enhancement. It is thus not surprising to see that numerous followers interpreted influencer-sponsored posts from the perspective of a self-fulfillment narrative, believing that influencers who are posting sponsored posts have earned brand endorsement and are thus successful individuals. A 22-year-old male, Roy, put it as follows when being asked how he thinks of his favorite influencer's promotion of sponsored products:

> "Feeling he is getting more successful and he was actually the right person to follow. Of course, I will judge this based on my own results (that) I obtain, and his advice as well."

Also, the participants also mentioned that since the things that influencers have been sharing are inspiring and useful to followers, they should be rewarded with monetary incentives such as brand sponsorships. Juri, a 27-year-old female, explained that:

> "If he is putting his knowledge into his sponsored posts, I will still watch his videos. … If that allows him to gain monetary incentives, it is understandable."

Last, it is also worth noting that almost all participants revealed that their compassion and appreciation of influencers' sharing, including sponsored content, are based on multiple "default" conditions. For example, they expect that influencers will constantly produce valuable and relevant content; influencers do not commit any major blunders and remain constant sources of inspirations; and/or influencers keep a well-versed balance between sponsored content and organic sharing. Nina, a 22-year-old female, described that she will unfollow her favorite influencer if the following happens:

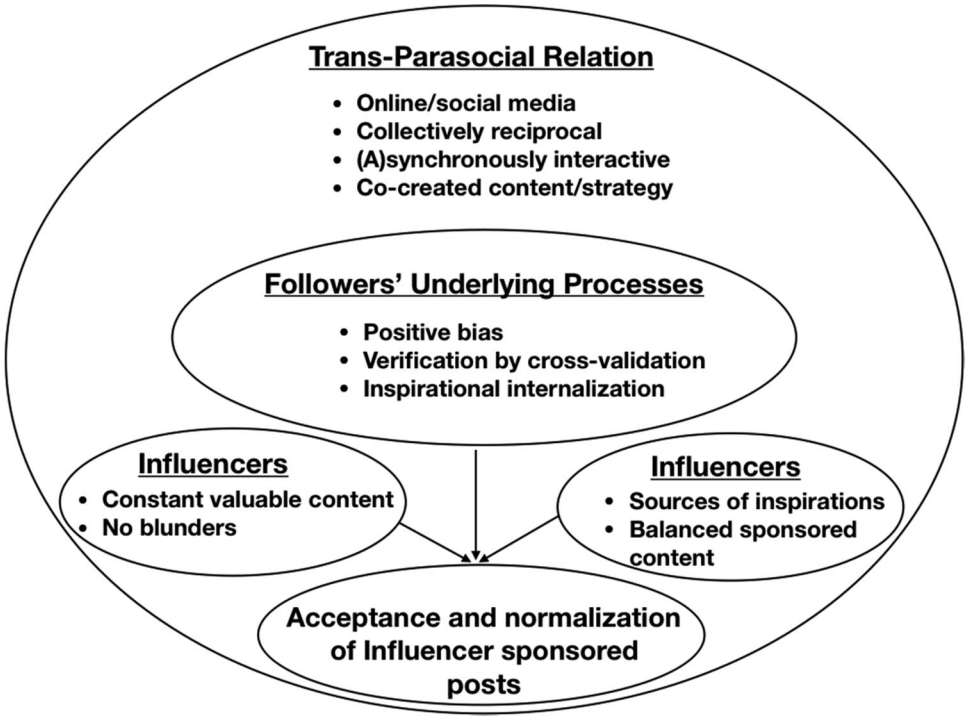

Figure 2. The processes through which followers react to influencer-sponsored content in view of the trans-parasocial relation and default expectations.

> "I think it's the content of their videos, if they get less interesting or if they have too many sponsorships, then I will be less inclined to follow them."

Figure 2 efficiently summarizes the processes through which followers react to influencer-sponsored content in view of their trans-parasocial relation with influencers, as well as the default conditions and expectations toward influencers.

Discussion

This study reconfigures the conceptualization of parasocial relation in a way that surpasses the limitations of traditional media (TV and radio; one-to-many), the previous conversational structure (non-interactive), and the existing relation construction (created by producer) and recognizes the role of new technologies in social relation building. The trans-parasocial relation concept offers a foundation on which new communicative and advertising theories can be developed to explicate new forms of social interactions and consumer behavior. This influencer–follower relation lies at the intersection of parasocial relation and interpersonal relation, combines both one-to-one and one-to-many interactions, and facilitates collective reciprocity, (a)synchronous interactivity, and co-created social relations between social media influencers and their followers. These findings point to a new theorization of this updated and evolving format of "parasocial relation" in the influencer context, which this study terms as *trans-parasocial relation*. Subsequently, this study discusses, in view of this new form of relation, how followers or consumers react to influencer-sponsored posts, regardless of the provision of sponsorship disclosures, which differs from the predictions of the persuasion knowledge model. In particular, the findings revealed that followers tend to trust their favorite influencers and believe their sharing—including both organic sharing and sponsored posts—to be largely genuine. Three possible psychological mechanisms emerged to account for followers' acceptance of and overall benign attitudes toward influencer-sponsored posts: *positive bias*, *verification by cross-validation*, and *inspirational internalization*. Followers largely believe in the benign intent of the influencers' sharing and acknowledge the value of those posts despite the fact that they are being sponsored. Followers also self-justify that influencer-sponsored posts won't negatively influence them as they have autonomy over what to purchase and will also cross-reference other information sources before making purchase decisions. Last, the findings showed that followers often internalize influencers' sponsorship deals as inspirational fulfillments and celebrate influencers' success.

Theoretical Implications

The first major contribution of this study lies in the new theorization and explication of the trans-parasocial relation, which advances the current theorization of the parasocial relation and has implications for how social media users regard their interactions and relation formation with influencers and coordinate their consumption-related behaviors accordingly. From the very perspective of influencers, Abidin (2015) theorizes the relation between influencers and followers and proposes the notion of "perceived interconnectedness," which lists the aspects in which influencer–follower relation differs from the previous parasocial relation. Yet, no research has offered a clear, thorough, and granular theorization of this new relation from the perspective of followers. This study, corroborated by empirical evidence, filled this research gap by offering a clear and systematic typology explicating how the trans-parasocial relation advances the notion of parasocial relation and implicates new propositions, which, at the same time, validates some findings observed from the perspective of influencers (Abidin 2015).

This new theorization also broadly corresponds to what O'Sullivan and Carr (2018) called the "masspersonal communication" concept, which argues that new communication technologies challenge the divide between interpersonal and mass communication, thus "calling for new frameworks" (p. 1161). Essentially, afforded by new digital technologies, consumer interactions and communications are breaking the boundaries of basic assumptions about interpersonal communication, mass communication, and the concepts arising from the two. This study suggests that the long-held conventional concept—the parasocial relation—no longer fully encompasses all aspects of the evolving contemporary human interactions and related associations. Our analysis recommends an updated notion and theorization—the trans-parasocial relation—to capture the nuanced yet distinctive development of "media personae–audience" (influencer–follower) relation in the computer-mediated-communication (CMC)/mobile communication context. What sets this new definition apart from the parasocial relation is that it describes a relation that can be collectively reciprocal, meaning that, in a collective sense, the interaction between the two entities is reciprocal. For instance, influencers, as opinion leaders, reciprocate followers' requests purposely and respond to representative demands by curating content, replies, or live interactions. Also, this new trans-parasocial relation can be either synchronously or asynchronously interactive, meaning that influencers can interact with followers through real-time live streaming and offline meet-ups, or they can frequently interact with followers asynchronously after some time delay (e.g., replying to comments, shooting Q&A videos). Additionally, the trans-parasocial relation between influencers and followers is co-created, meaning that followers play an active role in the co-creation and development of influencers' offerings, values, aims, agenda setting, and motives along the progression of their relation.

The second major contribution of this study relates to the reconsideration of the predictions derived from the persuasion knowledge model. In the influencer context, recent research also found that the inclusion of sponsorship disclosure activates viewers' conceptual persuasion knowledge: recognition of advertising (e.g., Evans et al. 2017; De Jans and Hudders 2020; Van Reijmersdal et al. 2020). Some found that consumers' recognition of sponsored posts as advertising (versus no disclosure) gave rise to more critical attitudes, more skepticism, or less favorable outcomes toward the ads (e.g., Boerman, Van Reijmersdal, and Neijens 2012; Evans et al. 2017), whereas others demonstrated that persuasion knowledge—triggered by sponsorship disclosure—does not always bring about negative advertising outcomes (e.g., De Jans and Hudders 2020; Dhanesh and Duthler 2019; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019). Contrary to the propositions of the PKM, this study argues that influencers' sponsorship disclosure can make them come across as transparent, credible, and genuine to followers (Dhanesh and Duthler 2019), thus offsetting the negative effect of persuasion knowledge. This finding also echoed recent literature on covert advertising. Recent research has found that perceptions of sponsorship transparency mitigates the negative effect of advertising recognition of covert ads on consumer evaluations which, in turn, leads to increased source credibility, more favorable ad and brand attitudes, and greater eWOM and purchase intents (e.g., Campbell and Evans 2018; Evans, Wojdynski, and Grubbs Hoy 2019; Krouwer, Poels, and Paulussen 2020).

Previous studies that demonstrated the negative effect of PK largely followed the mere-exposure effect paradigm and looked into the effect of a single advertising message on viewers while dismissing the role of the micro environment—the intimate relation between viewers and senders (influencer–follower relation)—in which the advertising message is created and disseminated. However, in the influencer–follower context, followers often trust the influencers they follow as

much as they trust their friends (Swant 2016). Against the backdrop of this overarching relation, it is not surprising to see that most participants consider their favorite influencers credible and genuine and that they hold overall tolerant or benign attitudes—instead of critical attitudes—toward influencer-sponsored posts. More importantly, the participants mentioned that they understand the dynamics and particulars of the influencer business model and are in favor of influencers getting paid in sponsorships or other commercial activities to compensate their creation of free and useful content. Almost all participants acknowledge that a reasonable ratio of organic sharing and sponsored posts can definitely go hand-in-hand in sustaining influencers' content creation in the long run.

Last, this study uncovers the possible psychological coping mechanisms that expounds why followers react to influencer-sponsored posts benignly. First, this study found that followers show positive bias toward influencers' sponsorship deals. They indicate that they trust the influencers' ethics in managing sponsored activities and won't discount the potential value of sponsored posts just because the influencers are being sponsored. This echoes what Lou and colleagues (Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019) have found, that followers show "cultlike appreciation for influencers' product sharing" (p. 169) and actively engaged with influencer-promoted ads on Instagram. Second, it is worth noting that as much as followers trust their favorite influencers, they seem to be functioning like rational consumers (at least self-reportedly so): Almost all of them mentioned that they tend to cross-reference other sources about influencer-promoted products before making a purchase. This finding doesn't contradict their revelation of trust in influencers; instead, it evidences that they indeed take influencer-promoted products seriously and include them in the evoked set before making a purchase decision. Additionally, we found that followers tend to interpret influencer-sponsored activities with an inspirational twist. In particular, they consider influencers with sponsorship deals successful and inspiring, and they believe that influencers deserve monetary incentive that is commensurate with their inspirational trait and value. This finding agrees with what Ki and colleagues (2020) have argued: that influencers' inspiring personality is one major driver of followers' liking, following, and attachment. It is understandable that human beings are driven by self-enhancement goals (Allport 1937), and influencers, as "someone like me," serve as attainable role models.

Practical Implications

Informed by the current findings, generally speaking, influencers are advised to always demonstrate integrity in business handling (e.g., no purposeful deception) and engage in ethical commercial activities (e.g., no major blunders). Influencers should also treasure and grow their core equity through constantly creating useful and valuable content that satisfies followers' needs. As most followers see their favorite influencers as role models and sources of inspirations, influencers should also keep this in mind when curating their online personae.

Regarding relationship building between influencers and followers, our findings show that signaling collective reciprocity (e.g., free giveaways, catering to followers' requests), which may not be directed to each individual follower, can help build intimacy perceived by the followers. Also, influencers may try to be responsive, either synchronously or asynchronously, to followers' interactions to facilitate relation building with followers. Furthermore, influencers may continue taking followers' representative requests or demands into account, which can be reflected in content generation or the socialization process. Regarding advertisers and marketers who are interested in influencer campaigns, they are advised to seek influencers who have strong rapport with their followers and those who maintain a good reputation and credibility record among their followers. Advertisers should also assess the proportion of organic sharing and commercial posts for a given influencer to estimate his/her long-term appeal among followers.

Further, in terms of sponsorship activities, given that followers are largely tolerant and even appreciative of influencer-sponsored content, influencers should always ensure transparency with followers through clear sponsorship disclosures, which can bolster followers' trust in and satisfaction with them (Dhanesh and Duthler 2019). Influencers should also be aware of their significant impact on some of their fervid followers and avoid instigating impulse buying or blunt consumerism, especially among their adolescent followers or other vulnerable populations (Lou and Kim 2019). More importantly, in view of this enhanced and intensified relation between influencers and followers, current regulations (e.g., Federal Trade Commission 2017) that focus on enforcing sponsorship disclosures among influencers and brands may be insufficient. This indeed poses new challenges to regulatory bodies who oversee influencer marketing activities. More advanced regulations regarding influencer-sponsored posts (e.g., objective product

information, no false or misleading claims) and their online promoting strategies (e.g., promoting detrimental beauty ideals or taping into racism) should be closely scrutinized and supervised.

Limitations and Future Research Directions

This study has its limitations that invite future research. First, we caution that, due to the self-reported nature of interview studies, some participants may have distorted memories of their experiences and interactions with their favorite influencers. For example, although most influencers occasionally reciprocate or reply to followers' comments, a lot of the participants perceived a seemingly more intense and intimate interactions with influencers. This warrants further investigation into the formation of positive bias and information processing among followers. Furthermore, the current qualitative findings from in-depth interviews did not inform causal relations or correlations. Future research can invest more in measurement building or causality verifications through surveys or experiments. In particular, based on the current qualitative findings, future research can develop a new scale assessing this *trans-parasocial relation* via exploratory factor analysis and confirmatory factor analysis. Following this, future research can accurately pinpoint the antecedents of this relation and validate how related factors— including the characteristics of influencer-generated content, influencers' communicative style, or self-disclosure (e.g., Abidin 2015; Lou and Yuan 2019)—may affect this relation. Future research can also compare the predictive power of this new operationalization with that of the existing notion of parasocial relation and explicate how well they can predict advertising efficacy and consumer behavior.

Second, the current findings are based on social media users in Singapore. Having a diverse social makeup, a high penetration rate of social media use (75%), and one of the top economies characterized by gross domestic product per capita (Müller 2020; Worldometer 2020), Singapore has been recognized as a cosmopolitan hub that shares a lot of commonalities with other developed countries. More importantly, recent research on influencer practices that were conducted in Singapore has been well applied to other cultural contexts (e.g., Abidin 2015, 2016). Furthermore, a multitude of findings unearthed in this current study indeed replicate some previous findings conducted in other cultural sites (e.g., U.S., Belgium, Amsterdam) (e.g., Boerman and Van Reijmersdal 2020; Krouwer, Poels, and Paulussen 2020; Lou, Tan, and Chen 2019). Therefore, we argue that, regardless of the specific context in which this study was conducted, the fundamental theoretical underpinnings and arguments regarding influencer–-follower relation should remain robust in other cultural sites. Nonetheless, this also calls for testing from more cultural settings to corroborate the robustness of the current theoretical building of trans-parasocial relation. Future research can also test the role of cultural orientation or cultural-level values in the trans-parasocial relation and influencer advertising.

Third, given that the current findings echo recent literature on the essential role of influencer authenticity in influencer appeal or ethics (e.g., Campbell and Farrell 2020; Pöyry et al. 2019), future research may offer more in-depth explication of its theoretical underpinnings and explore its relation to trans-parasocial relation and persuasive outcomes. Furthermore, the current findings, in alignment with recent findings in the context of covert advertising, point to how influencer transparency can mitigate or even offset the negative effect of PK (e.g., Campbell and Evans 2018; Evans, Wojdynski, and Grubbs Hoy 2019; Krouwer, Poels, and Paulussen 2020). This suggests that the PKM can be expanded or fine-tuned in varied contexts. For instance, future research can explore how trans-parasocial relation moderates the impact of PK on advertising outcomes and explicate more granular mechanisms through which the negative impact of PK can be diminished. More importantly, it is imperative to examine and ascertain how and to what extent the current advertising literacy on influencer/covert advertising can inform vulnerable populations (e.g., kids, adolescents) when they are being exposed to influencers whom they have formed trans-parasocial relation. Regulatory bodies can subsequently implement more rigorous and timelier educative curriculum on influencer–follower relation and advertising literacy. Future research can also investigate how trans-parasocial relation can be leveraged to influence consumers' prosocial behaviors and cause marketing efficacy (e.g., employing influencers to promote mask wearing during the pandemic in Europe and Asia, or prejudice reduction).

Acknowledgment

The author would like to thank Shermaine Sng for her assistance. The author also thanks the reviewers and editors for their guidance.

Disclosure statement

The funder did not play any role in the entire research process. The author has no conflict of interest to disclose.

Funding

This study was supported by a Tier 1 grant from the Ministry of Education, Singapore (grant number M4012201.060).

ORCID

Chen Lou http://orcid.org/0000-0002-5506-5835

References

Abidin, C. 2015. Communicative intimacies: Influencers and perceived interconnectedness. *Ada: A Journal of Gender, New Media, & Technology* 8:1–16. http://adanewmedia.org/2015/11/issue8-abidin/.

Abidin, C. 2016. Aren't these just young, rich women doing vain things online?: Influencer selfies as subversive frivolity. *Social Media + Society* 2 (2):205630511664134. doi.org/10.1177/2056305116641342. doi:10.1177/2056305116641342

Abidin, C., and E. C. Thompson. 2012. Buymylife.com: Cyberfemininities and commercial intimacy in blogshops. *Women's Studies International Forum* 35 (6): 467–77. doi:10.1016/j.wsif.2012.10.005

Allport, G. W. 1937. *Personality: A psychological interpretation*. New York, NY: Holt.

Blattberg, R. C., and J. Deighton. 1991. Interactive marketing: Exploiting the age of addressability. *Sloan Management Review* 33 (1):5–15.

Boerman, S. C., E. A. Van Reijmersdal, and P. C. Neijens. 2012. Sponsorship disclosure: Effects of duration on persuasion knowledge and brand responses. *Journal of Communication* 62 (6):1047–64. doi:10.1111/j.1460-2466.2012.01677.x

Boerman, S. C., and E. A. Van Reijmersdal. 2020. Disclosing influencer marketing on YouTube to children: The moderating role of para-social relationship. *Frontiers in Psychology*, 10:3042.

Boerman, S. C., L. M. Willemsen, and E. P. Van Der Aa. 2017. 'This post is sponsored': Effects of sponsorship disclosure on persuasion knowledge and electronic word of mouth in the context of Facebook. *Journal of Interactive Marketing* 38:82–92. doi:10.1016/j.intmar.2016.12.002

Bond, B. J. 2016. Following your "friend": Social media and the strength of adolescents' parasocial relationships with media personae. *Cyberpsychology, Behavior, and Social Networking* 19 (11):656–60. doi:10.1089/cyber.2016.0355

Bond, B. J. 2018. Parasocial relationships with media personae: Why they matter and how they differ among heterosexual, lesbian, gay, and bisexual adolescents. *Media Psychology* 21 (3):457–85. doi:10.1080/15213269.2017.1416295

Campbell, C., and N. J. Evans. 2018. The role of a companion banner and sponsorship transparency in recognizing and evaluating article-style native advertising. *Journal of Interactive Marketing* 43:17–32. doi:10.1016/j.intmar.2018.02.002

Campbell, C., and J. R. Farrell. 2020. More than meets the eye: The functional components underlying influencer marketing. *Business Horizons* 63 (4):469–79. doi.org/10.1016/j.bushor.2020.03.003. doi:10.1016/j.bushor.2020.03.003

Chang, J. H.-Y. 2003. Culture, state and economic development in Singapore. *Journal of Contemporary Asia* 33 (1): 85–105. doi:10.1080/00472330380000071

Chen, C.-P. 2016. Forming digital self and parasocial relationships on YouTube. *Journal of Consumer Culture* 16 (1):232–54. doi:10.1177/1469540514521081

Chen, H., and E. Haley. 2014. Product placement in social games: Consumer experiences in China. *Journal of Advertising* 43 (3):286–95. doi:10.1080/00913367.2013.858086

Childers, C., L. L. Lemon, and M. G. Hoy. 2019. #Sponsored# Ad: Agency perspective on influencer marketing campaigns. *Journal of Current Issues & Research in Advertising* 40 (3):258–74.

Colliander, J., and M. Dahlén. 2011. Following the fashionable friend: The power of social media. *Journal of Advertising Research* 51 (1):313–20. doi:10.2501/JAR-51-1-313-320

Corbin, J., and A. Strauss. 2008. *Basics of qualitative research: Techniques and procedures for developing grounded theory*, 3rd ed. Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE.

De Jans, S., V. Cauberghe, and L. Hudders. 2018. How an advertising disclosure alerts young adolescents to sponsored vlogs: The moderating role of a peer-based advertising literacy intervention through an informational vlog. *Journal of Advertising* 47 (4):309–25. doi:10.1080/00913367.2018.1539363

De Jans, S., and L. Hudders. 2020. Disclosure of vlog advertising targeted to children. *Journal of Interactive Marketing* 52:1–19. doi:10.1016/j.intmar.2020.03.003

De Veirman, M., V. Cauberghe, and L. Hudders. 2017. Marketing through Instagram influencers: The impact of number of followers and product divergence on brand attitude. *International Journal of Advertising* 36 (5): 798–828. doi:10.1080/02650487.2017.1348035

De Veirman, M., and L. Hudders. 2020. Disclosing sponsored Instagram posts: The role of material connection with the brand and message-sidedness when disclosing covert advertising. *International Journal of Advertising* 39 (1):94–130. doi:10.1080/02650487.2019.1575108

De Veirman, M., L. Hudders, and M. R. Nelson. 2019. What is influencer marketing and how does it target children? A review and direction for future research. *Frontiers in Psychology* 10:2685. doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02685

Dhanesh, G. S., and G. Duthler. 2019. Relationship management through social media influencers: Effects of followers' awareness of paid endorsement. *Public Relations Review* 45 (3):101765. doi:10.1016/j.pubrev.2019.03.002

Dibble, J. L., T. Hartmann, and S. F. Rosaen. 2016. Parasocial interaction and parasocial relationship: Conceptual clarification and a critical assessment of measures. *Human Communication Research* 42 (1):21–44. doi:10.1111/hcre.12063

Djafarova, E., and C. Rushworth. 2017. Exploring the credibility of online celebrities' Instagram profiles in influencing the purchase decisions of young female users. *Computers in Human Behavior* 68:1–7. doi:10.1016/j.chb.2016.11.009

Erdogan, B. Z. 1999. Celebrity endorsement: A literature review. *Journal of Marketing Management* 15 (4): 291–314. doi:10.1362/026725799784870379

Escalas, J. E., and J. R. Bettman. 2017. Connecting with celebrities: How consumers appropriate celebrity meanings for a sense of belonging. *Journal of Advertising* 46 (2):297–308. doi:10.1080/00913367.2016.1274925

Evans, N. J., M. G. Hoy, and C. C. Childers. 2018. Parenting 'YouTube natives': The impact of pre-roll advertising and text disclosures on parental responses to sponsored child influencer videos. *Journal of Advertising* 47 (4):326–46. doi:10.1080/00913367.2018.1544952

Evans, N. J., J. Phua, J. Lim, and H. Jun. 2017. Disclosing Instagram influencer advertising: The effects of disclosure language on advertising recognition, attitudes, and behavioral intent. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 17 (2):138–49. doi:10.1080/15252019.2017.1366885

Evans, N. J., B. W. Wojdynski, and M. Grubbs Hoy. 2019. How sponsorship transparency mitigates negative effects of advertising recognition. *International Journal of Advertising* 38 (3):364–82. doi:10.1080/02650487.2018.1474998

Federal Trade Commission. 2017, April 19. "FTC Staff Reminds Influencers and Brands to Clearly Disclose Relationship."https://www.ftc.gov/news-events/press-releases/2017/04/ftc-staff-reminds-influencers-brands-clearly-disclose.

Friestad, M., and P. Wright. 1994. The persuasion knowledge model: How people cope with persuasion attempts. *Journal of Consumer Research* 21 (1):1–31. doi:10.1086/209380

Glaser, B. G. 1965. The constant comparative method of qualitative analysis. *Social Problems* 12 (4):436–45. doi:10.2307/798843

Government of Singapore. 2019. What are the racial proportions among Singapore citizens? https://www.gov.sg/article/what-are-the-racial-proportions-among-singapore-citizens.

Haley, E. 1996. Exploring the construct of organization as source: Consumers' understandings of organizational sponsorship of advocacy advertising. *Journal of Advertising* 25 (2):19–35. doi:10.1080/00913367.1996.10673497

Hirschman, E. C. 1986. Humanistic inquiry in marketing research: Philosophy, method, and criteria. *Journal of Marketing Research* 23 (3):237–49. doi:10.1177/002224378602300304

Horton, D., and R. R. Wohl. 1956. Mass communication and para-social interaction: Observations on intimacy at a distance. *Psychiatry* 19 (3):215–29. doi:10.1080/00332747.1956.11023049

Hwang, K., and Q. Zhang. 2018. Influence of parasocial relationship between digital celebrities and their followers on followers' purchase and electronic word-of-mouth intentions, and persuasion knowledge. *Computers in Human Behavior* 87:155–73. doi:10.1016/j.chb.2018.05.029

Influencer Marketing Hub. 2020. 80 influencer marketing statistics for 2020. https://influencermarketinghub.com/influencer-marketing-statistics/.

Jung, A.-R., and J. Heo. 2019. Ad disclosure vs. ad recognition: How persuasion knowledge influences native advertising evaluation. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 19 (1):1–14. doi:10.1080/15252019.2018.1520661

Kaikati, J. G. 1987. Celebrity advertising: A review and synthesis. *International Journal of Advertising* 6 (2):93–105. doi:10.1080/02650487.1987.11107007

Kay, S., R. Mulcahy, and J. Parkinson. 2020. When less is more: The impact of macro and micro social media influencers' disclosure. *Journal of Marketing Management* 36 (3–4):248–78. doi:10.1080/0267257X.2020.1718740

Ki, C.-W. (C.), L. M. Cuevas, S. M. Chong, and H. Lim. 2020. Influencer marketing: Social media influencers as human brands attaching to followers and yielding positive marketing results by fulfilling needs. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services* 55:102133. doi:10.1016/j.jretconser.2020.102133

Krouwer, S., K. Poels, and S. Paulussen. 2020. Moving towards transparency for native advertisements on news websites: A test of more detailed disclosures. *International Journal of Advertising* 39 (1):51–73. doi:10.1080/02650487.2019.1575107

Leskin, P. 2020. I spent a day following an Instagram influencer around New York City to see what her job was really like. Business Insider, January. https://www.businessinsider.com/influencer-day-in-the-life-courtkelly-courtney-seamon-photos-2019-10.

Li, J., Tang, J. Y. Wang, Y. Wan, Yi Chang, and H. Liu. 2018. Understanding and predicting delay in reciprocal relations. Proceedings of the 2018 World Wide Web Conference 2018:1643–52. doi:10.1145/3178876.3186076

Lincoln, Y. S., and E. G. Guba. 1985. *Naturalistic inquiry*. Newbury Park, CA: Sage.

Lou, C., and H. K. Kim. 2019. Fancying the new rich and famous? Explicating the roles of influencer content, credibility, and parental mediation in adolescents' parasocial relationship, materialism, and purchase intentions. *Frontiers in Psychology* 10:2567. doi:10.3389/fpsyg.2019.02567

Lou, C., S.-S. Tan, and X. Chen. 2019. Investigating consumer engagement with influencer-vs. brand-promoted ads: The roles of source and disclosure. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 19 (3):169–86. doi:10.1080/15252019.2019.1667928

Lou, C., and S. Yuan. 2019. Influencer marketing: How message value and credibility affect consumer trust of branded content on social media. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 19 (1):58–73. doi:10.1080/15252019.2018.1533501

Mohsin, M. 2020. 10 Instagram stats every marketer should know in 2020. Oberlo, February. https://www.oberlo.com/blog/instagram-stats-every-marketer-should-know.

Müller, J. 2019. Share of respondents who have been persuaded to purchase a product by a social media influencer in Singapore as of August 2018, by age group. Statista. https://www.statista.com/statistics/950956/singapore-social-media-influencers-reach/.

Müller, J. 2020. Social media in Singapore – Statistics & facts. Statista. https://www.statista.com/topics/5815/social-media-in-singapore/.

O'Neil-Hart, C., and H. Blumenstein. 2016. Why YouTube stars are more influential than traditional celebrities. Google, July. https://www.thinkwithgoogle.com/consumer-insights/youtube-stars-influence/

O'Sullivan, P. B., and C. T. Carr. 2018. Masspersonal communication: A model bridging the mass-interpersonal divide. *New Media & Society* 20 (3):1161–80. doi:10.1177/1461444816686104

Omnicore. 2020. YouTube by the numbers: Stats, demographic & fun facts. https://www.omnicoreagency.com/youtube-statistics/.

Pöyry, E., M. Pelkonen, E. Naumanen, and S.-M. Laaksonen. 2019. A call for authenticity: Audience responses to social media influencer endorsements in strategic communication. *International Journal of Strategic Communication* 13 (4):336–51. doi:10.1080/1553118X.2019.1609965

Rozendaal, E., M. A. Lapierre, E. A. Van Reijmersdal, and M. Buijzen. 2011. Reconsidering advertising literacy as a defense against advertising effects. *Media Psychology* 14 (4):333–54. doi:10.1080/15213269.2011.620540

Russell, C. A., B. B. Stern, and B. B. Stern. 2006. Consumers, characters, and products: A balance model of sitcom product placement effects. *Journal of Advertising* 35 (1):7–21. doi:10.2753/JOA0091-3367350101

Schomer, A. 2019. Influencer marketing: State of the social media influencer market in 2020. Business Insider, December. https://www.businessinsider.com/influencer-marketing-report.

Schouten, A. P., L. Janssen, and M. Verspaget. 2020. Celebrity vs. influencer endorsements in advertising: The role of identification, credibility, and product endorser fit. *International Journal of Advertising* 39 (2):258–81. doi:10.1080/02650487.2019.1634898

Sokolova, K., and H. Kefi. 2020. Instagram and YouTube bloggers promote it, why should I buy? How credibility and parasocial interaction influence purchase intentions. *Journal of Retailing and Consumer Services* 53:101742. doi:10.1016/j.jretconser.2019.01.011

Steuer, J. 1992. Defining virtual reality: Dimensions determining telepresence. *Journal of Communication* 42 (4): 73–93. doi:10.1111/j.1460-2466.1992.tb00812.x

Swant, M. 2016. Twitter says users now trust influencers nearly as much as their friends. Adweek, May. http://www.adweek.com/digital/twitter-says-users-now-trust-influencers-nearly-much-their-friends-171367/.

Tracy, S. J. 2013. *Qualitative research methods: Collecting evidence, crafting analysis, communicating impact*. Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell.

Tsai, W.-H S., and L. R. Men. 2013. Motivations and antecedents of consumer engagement with brand pages on social networking sites. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 13 (2):76–87. doi:10.1080/15252019.2013.826549

Van Dam, S., and E. van Reijmersdal. 2019. Insights in adolescents' advertising literacy, perceptions and responses regarding sponsored influencer videos and disclosures. *Cyberpsychology: Journal of Psychosocial Research on Cyberspace* 13 (2):2. doi:10.5817/CP2019-2-2

Van Reijmersdal, E. A., and S. van Dam. 2020. How age and disclosures of sponsored influencer videos affect adolescents' knowledge of persuasion and persuasion. *Journal of Youth and Adolescence* 49 (7):1531–44. doi:10.1007/s10964-019-01191-z

Van Reijmersdal, E. A., E. Rozendaal, L. Hudders, I. Vanwesenbeeck, V. Cauberghe, and Z. M. van Berlo. 2020. Effects of disclosing influencer marketing in videos: An eye tracking study among children in early adolescence. *Journal of Interactive Marketing* 49:94–106. doi:10.1016/j.intmar.2019.09.001

Weinswig, D. 2016. Influencers are the new brands. Forbes, October. https://www.forbes.com/sites/deborahweinswig/2016/10/05/influencers-are-the-new-brands/#41a786447919.

Wojdynski, B. W., and N. J. Evans. 2016. Going native: Effects of disclosure position and language on the recognition and evaluation of online native advertising. *Journal of Advertising* 45 (2):157–68. doi:10.1080/00913367.2015.1115380

Worldometer. 2020. GDP per capita. https://www.worldometers.info/gdp/gdp-per-capita/.

Yuan, S., and C. Lou. 2020. How social media influencers foster relationships with followers: The Roles of source credibility and fairness in parasocial relationship and product interest. *Journal of Interactive Advertising* 20 (2): 133–47. doi:10.1080/15252019.2020.1769514